

COMETS

With its great glowing tail, a brilliant comet is an awesome sight. Ancient civilizations saw these streaks of light in the sky as omens of doom, but a comet is simply a large chunk of ice and dust orbiting the Sun. Comets come from the edge of the Solar System – in the Oort Cloud, which is home to billions of comets.

In 1996, Comet Hyakutake made one of the closest approaches of any comet in the last 200 years. Seen by many people, it was easily visible in the night sky.

The small, solid nucleus erupts into life as it nears the Sun

Pressure from the Sun's light pushes dust from the comet out into a tail that reflects the sunlight.

Gas and dust from the nucleus forms a "head" (coma) that can grow as large as the Sun